A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

# The Weightless King

*A sermon on Belshazzar*

THE BIG IDEA

*The king who weighed nothing threw a feast with the vessels of God, and the hand that held his breath wrote his sentence on the wall.*

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| PRIMARY TEXT | Daniel 5:1–31 |
| ALSO READ | Daniel 4:28–37; Proverbs 16:18; Isaiah 47:10–11; Jeremiah 50:29–32; Luke 12:16–21; Colossians 2:13–15 |
| TIME | 50–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response. |

*Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.*



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# Introduction: The night the music stopped

You have used the phrase even if you have never read the chapter.

"The writing on the wall." We say it when a company is failing, when a marriage is cracking, when a politician is finished, when the numbers have turned and everyone in the room knows it. The phrase has become a cartoon. It shows up in business magazines and memes, usually next to a picture of a worried man in a suit.

But the original story is not a business metaphor. It is a party that turned into an execution.

It happened in Babylon, in 539 BC, in a palace built to make other nations feel small. The king was Belshazzar, son of Nabonidus and co-regent of the city. He was young enough to believe the night belonged to him. He had a thousand lords in the room, his wives and concubines at the table, wine in every hand, and the gold and silver vessels of the Jerusalem temple in front of him.

They were drinking from the cups of God and praising gods they had made with their own hands. And then a hand appeared in the air and began to write on the wall.

Not a sword. Not an angel with a drawn blade. A hand. Fingers. It wrote four words on the plaster, and the room that had been roaring with laughter went absolutely silent.

That is where we are going this morning. We are going to stand in that room. We are going to watch the most powerful man in the world lose control of his own body. We are going to hear an old exile tell the truth for free. And we are going to read the sentence that was already written before the king knew his name was in it.

Because this story is not chiefly about ancient Babylon. It is about the difference between holding the things of God and belonging to the God who holds your breath.

The big idea is this: The king who weighed nothing threw a feast with the vessels of God, and the hand that held his breath wrote his sentence on the wall.

Let us walk into the room.

# Movement 1: The feast and the vessels

"King Belshazzar made a great feast for a thousand of his lords and drank wine in front of the thousand" (Daniel 5:1).

Start with the scale. A thousand nobles. That is not a dinner party. That is a political machine. You do not invite a thousand lords because you enjoy their company. You invite them because you want them to see you. You want them to eat your food, drink your wine, admire your gold, and remember who is in charge.

Babylon was a city built for that kind of display. The walls were famous. The Ishtar Gate was covered in blue-glazed brick and dragons. The Euphrates ran through the middle of the city. This was the city that had taken Judah into exile, destroyed the temple, and carried its holy things away. It was the superpower.

And Belshazzar was the host.

He was not Nebuchadnezzar. That is the first thing to get straight. Nebuchadnezzar was the one who built the empire, the one who burned Jerusalem, the one who went mad in Daniel 4 and ate grass like an ox until he looked up and acknowledged the Most High. Belshazzar was his successor in the royal line. The text calls Nebuchadnezzar his father, which in the language of the court can mean ancestor or predecessor. Historically, Belshazzar was the son of Nabonidus and ruled Babylon as co-regent while his father was away. He was not the empire's architect. He was the heir of a machine he did not build, and he seems to have believed that the machine would run forever.

That is a dangerous combination in any generation: a man who inherits power, does not understand it, and has never been made to kneel.

"While he tasted the wine, Belshazzar gave orders to bring the gold and silver vessels that Nebuchadnezzar his father had taken out of the temple that was in Jerusalem, so that the king and his lords, his wives, and his concubines might drink from them" (Daniel 5:2).

The wine is doing something in this verse. It is not just a beverage. It is a loosening agent. Wine has a way of taking the brakes off the soul. A man who would never say a thing sober will say it after the third cup. A man who would never touch a sacred object in the light of day will call for it at midnight.

What Belshazzar wanted was not a drink. He wanted a display. He wanted the lords of his empire to see him drinking from the cups of the conquered God. It was a theological statement dressed up as a toast. The God of Israel had been beaten, the vessels were trophies, and the king was going to turn the trophies into barware.

This is what the temple vessels were. They were not decorations. They were set apart. They had been made for the worship of the living God in the house where his name dwelt. The bread of

the Presence was placed on the table. The lampstand burned with oil. The cups and basins were used in the service of the sanctuary. They were holy not because gold is magic, but because God had claimed them for himself.

And now they are in a pagan banquet hall, filled with wine, lifted in a thousand hands, and used to praise gods of gold and silver, bronze and iron, wood and stone.

Do you see the irony? The room is praising gods made of the same material as the cups. Gold and silver. Bronze and iron. Wood and stone. The king is worshiping the stuff he is holding. He has taken the things of the living God and used them to celebrate gods who cannot see or hear or know.

That is what idolatry always does. It takes something created and gives it the weight that belongs only to the Creator. It can be a statue in a temple. It can be a portfolio. It can be a reputation. It can be a family. It can be a country. It can be a ministry. It can be the sound of a thousand people applauding at once.

Idolatry is not usually a decision to reject God. It is a decision to use God's things for our own glory. It is the difference between a vessel and a trophy. A vessel is something that carries the treasure. A trophy is something that displays the owner.

Belshazzar had the vessels of God on his table, and he did not have the God of the vessels in his heart. He had the furniture of worship without the Lord of worship. He had the gold without the presence.

That is possible. That is possible for a king. It is possible for a church. It is possible for a preacher. It is possible for you.

We do not drink from temple cups. But we have sacred things. We have the Scriptures. We have the Lord's Supper. We have the name of Jesus. We have the people made in the image of God. And every one of them can become a prop in a room where we are the center of attention.

The question this chapter asks is not whether you have holy things in your life. The question is whether the Holy One has you.

The party is roaring. The wine is flowing. The gods of gold and silver are being praised. And then the room hears something it cannot explain.

# Movement 2: The hand and the fear

"Immediately the fingers of a human hand appeared and wrote on the plaster of the wall of the king's palace, opposite the lampstand. And the king saw the hand as it wrote" (Daniel 5:5).

I want you to notice how quiet this is.

There is no thunder. No earthquake. No angel announces the arrival. A hand appears, and it writes. That is all. It is almost understated. The room is loud enough to drown out a conversation, and God speaks in a way that cannot be drowned out at all.

The hand writes on the plaster. This is not a stone monument. It is the wall of a palace, covered in smooth plaster, the kind of surface a finger can mark. It is opposite the lampstand, which means the light is on it. The king can see it. Everyone can see it.

The text says the king saw the hand as it wrote. That detail matters. He did not see the writing after the fact and ask what had happened. He watched the fingers move. He saw the hand of God at work, and he could not pretend it was a trick of the light.

What kind of hand was it? The text says the fingers of a human hand. Not a beast's claw. Not a warrior's fist. A hand. The God who is spirit condescends to write with fingers, the way a parent writes a note and leaves it on the table.

It is the same finger that wrote the law on stone. "And he gave to Moses, when he had finished speaking with him on Mount Sinai, the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written with the finger of God" (Exodus 31:18). The God who wrote the commandment now writes the verdict. The hand that gave the law is the hand that reads the king's life against it.

And watch what happens to Belshazzar.

"Then the king's color changed, and his thoughts alarmed him; his limbs gave way, and his knees knocked together" (Daniel 5:6).

His color changed. The Hebrew behind that phrase is vivid; the Aramaic literally says his brightness changed. The blood drained from his face. The man who had been the center of the room went pale.

His thoughts alarmed him. The party noise is still going on in the background, but inside his head there is a siren.

His limbs gave way. The version I learned as a boy said his knees knocked together, and that is the picture. The legs that carried him to the throne will not carry him now. The man who commanded a thousand lords cannot hold his own body upright.

This is what the fear of God looks like when it arrives unannounced. It is not a religious mood. It is not a pleasant feeling in the chest. It is the realization that the room you thought you owned has a Lord, and you are not him.

The book of Daniel is full of kings who find this out. Nebuchadnezzar found it out in the field, eating grass, with his hair grown long like eagles' feathers. Darius found it out in the lions' den. Belshazzar is finding it out at his own table, with a cup still in his hand.

And the first thing he does is try to manage the moment.

"The king called loudly to bring in the enchanters, the Chaldeans, and the diviners. The king declared to the wise men of Babylon, 'Whoever reads this writing, and shows me its interpretation, shall be clothed with purple and have a chain of gold around his neck and shall be the third ruler in the kingdom'" (Daniel 5:7).

He does what powerful men do when they are afraid. He outsources the problem. He calls the experts. He offers a reward. He tries to turn a verdict into a transaction.

Purple, gold, and third place. That is the currency of the kingdom. It is also a measure of how much he understands. He is offering the third seat in a kingdom that is about to be taken from him. He is promising a future he does not have the power to guarantee.

And the experts fail.

"Then all the king's wise men came in, but they could not read the writing or make known to the king its interpretation" (Daniel 5:8).

Why could they not read it? The words are simple. Mene, tekel, parsin. Any Aramaic speaker could pronounce them. But the meaning was hidden. The text says they could not read the writing or make known the interpretation. The wise men of Babylon had spent their lives studying the stars, the liver, the dreams, the gods. They had a whole system. And when God wrote four words on a wall, their system had nothing to say.

That is a frightening sentence for anyone who trades in expertise. It is possible to be an expert in religion and still not know God. It is possible to have a file on every doctrine and no ear for the voice that made the doctrine necessary. The wise men could not read the handwriting because the author was not in their library.

The king is more afraid now. "Then King Belshazzar was greatly alarmed, and his color changed, and his lords were perplexed" (Daniel 5:9). The fear has spread from the throne to the room. The lords are looking at each other. The music has stopped in every practical sense. The most secure room in the world has become a waiting room.

Here is the question I want to put to you before we go further: What would it take for you to hear the sentence?

Not a hand on the wall. Something smaller, probably. A diagnosis. A closed door. A conversation you have been avoiding. A pattern you cannot break. A quiet sense that the life you are building is not as solid as you pretend. The king's body knew before his mind did. His knees were preaching the truth his mouth would not say.

The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom (Proverbs 9:10). But fear by itself is not wisdom. It is only the door. Belshazzar is standing at the door, and he does not go through it. He calls for more experts. He raises the reward. He tries to buy his way out of the room.

And then a woman walks in.

## Movement 3: The queen, the prophet, and the refusal

"The queen, because of the words of the king and his lords, came into the banqueting hall. The queen declared, 'O king, live forever! Let not your thoughts alarm you or your color change'" (Daniel 5:10).

We do not know her name. The text calls her the queen, and most interpreters think she was the queen mother, the widow of a former king or the mother of Belshazzar. She is not one of the wives and concubines at the table. She comes in from outside. She has heard the commotion, and she has come to speak sense.

Think about the courage of that. This is a room full of drunken lords, a frightened king, and a hand writing on the wall. A woman walks in. In that culture, that is not a small thing. She is not invited. She is not on the program. And she is the only person in the building who knows what to do.

Her first words are court etiquette: "O king, live forever." But her message is a funeral. She says, in effect, I know a man who can read this.

"There is a man in your kingdom in whom is the spirit of the holy gods. In the days of your father, light and understanding and wisdom like the wisdom of the gods were found in him, and King Nebuchadnezzar, your father—your father the king—made him chief of the magicians, enchanters, Chaldeans, and diviners" (Daniel 5:11).

She remembers Daniel.

That is the sentence that should sting. The king had forgotten him. The kingdom had moved on. There were new wise men, new gods, new parties. But the queen mother kept the file. She knew the stories. She knew that when Nebuchadnezzar had a dream that terrified him, Daniel was the one who told him the truth. She knew that when the writing appeared on the wall of the king's heart, Daniel had been there before.

The faithful are easily forgotten in the corridors of power. The people who prayed for the city, who kept the records, who told the truth when it was expensive—they do not usually get their names on the gate. But when the handwriting comes, the room remembers where the wisdom lives.

"Because an excellent spirit, knowledge, and understanding to interpret dreams, explain riddles, and solve problems were found in this Daniel, whom the king named Belteshazzar. Now let Daniel be called, and he will show the interpretation" (Daniel 5:12).

Notice the name. Belteshazzar. The Babylonians gave Daniel a new name when he was a teenager, a name that honored their gods. He had carried it for sixty years. He had served under Nebuchadnezzar, under Belshazzar's father, and now under Belshazzar. He had outlasted the kings. He had outlasted the empire's confidence. He was an old man by now, an exile from a small province, and he was still standing.

Daniel is brought in. The king looks at him and asks, "Are you Daniel, one of the exiles of Judah, whom the king my father brought from Judah?" (Daniel 5:13).

It is a strange way to begin. He identifies Daniel by his exile. The king is reminding him of his place. You are a captive. You are a foreigner. You are here because my father conquered your people. The king is trying to establish the pecking order before the old man opens his mouth.

Daniel is not impressed.

"I have heard of you, that the spirit of the gods is in you, and that light and understanding and excellent wisdom are found in you" (Daniel 5:14). He has heard of him. Hearsay. The king has a

reputation on file, but he does not know the man. He does not know the God who gave the wisdom.

Then he makes the offer again. Purple. Gold. Third ruler. The same reward. The same transaction.

And Daniel refuses it.

"Let your gifts be for yourself, and give your rewards to another. Nevertheless, I will read the writing to the king and make known to him the interpretation" (Daniel 5:17).

This is one of the great moments of integrity in the Bible. Daniel does not refuse to speak. He refuses to be bought. He will read the writing for free. He will tell the king the truth, and he will not take a dime for it.

Think about what that means. Daniel has been in Babylon for decades. He has watched empires assume they will last forever. He has seen what happens to prophets who tell kings what they want to hear. He knows the reward is a trap. If he takes the purple, he becomes part of the system that is about to be judged. He would rather be a free man in a doomed city than a rich man in a lying one.

The word of God is not for sale. That is the principle. It is not a product to be marketed, a performance to be paid for, a message to be softened so the room will keep applauding. Daniel stands in front of a king who can kill him with a word, and he says, keep your gifts.

I want to say something carefully here, because it would be easy to misapply this. The Bible is not against preachers being paid. "The laborer deserves his wages" (Luke 10:7). "The Lord commanded that those who proclaim the gospel should get their living by the gospel" (1 Corinthians 9:14). The problem is not the salary. The problem is the price. The problem is when the message changes because the room is paying. The problem is when a prophet becomes a performer.

Daniel could speak freely because he had nothing to lose. That is the freedom the gospel gives. When your identity is in the King of heaven, the purple and the chain lose their power. When your treasure is in the kingdom that cannot be shaken, the third seat in Babylon is not a promotion. It is a demotion.

The king is trying to buy a verdict. Daniel is about to show him that the verdict has already been written.

# Movement 4: MENE MENE TEKEL PARSIN

Daniel does not start with the writing. He starts with the history.

"O king, the Most High God gave Nebuchadnezzar your father kingship and greatness and glory and majesty. And because of the greatness that he gave him, all peoples, nations, and languages trembled and feared before him. Whom he would, he killed, and whom he would, he kept alive; whom he would, he lifted up, and whom he would, he humbled" (Daniel 5:18–19).

This is not flattery. It is evidence. Daniel is building a case. He is saying: your family has seen the Most High at work. You have a history. You have a record. You have a grandfather or a predecessor who went mad and was restored, and the whole thing is on the books.

"But when his heart was lifted up and his spirit was hardened so that he dealt proudly, he was brought down from his royal throne, and his glory was taken from him. He was driven from among the children of mankind, and his mind was made like that of a beast, and his dwelling was with the wild donkeys. He was fed grass like an ox, and his body was wet with the dew of heaven, until he knew that the Most High God rules the kingdom of mankind and sets over it whom he will" (Daniel 5:20–21).

That is the story of Daniel 4. Nebuchadnezzar looked out over Babylon and said, "Is not this great Babylon, which I have built by my mighty power as a royal residence and for the glory of my majesty?" (Daniel 4:30). While the words were still in his mouth, a voice from heaven pronounced the sentence. He was driven out. He ate grass. His hair and nails grew. He lived like a beast until he lifted his eyes to heaven and his reason returned.

Belshazzar knew that story.

"And you his son, Belshazzar, have not humbled your heart, though you knew all this" (Daniel 5:22).

There it is. That is the verse that makes this chapter more than a cautionary tale about a bad king. Belshazzar did not sin in ignorance. He knew. He had the family record. He had the testimony of the man who was restored. He had the evidence, and he refused the lesson.

That is the particular danger of a religious inheritance. You can grow up hearing the stories and never let them weigh you. You can know all the ways God has humbled other people and still believe you are the exception. You can sit in the same room as the truth for a lifetime and never let it get near your heart.

"You have lifted up yourself against the Lord of heaven. And the vessels of his house have been brought in before you, and you and your lords, your wives, and your concubines have drunk wine from them. And you have praised the gods of silver and gold, of bronze, iron, wood, and stone, which do not see or hear or know, but the God in whose hand is your breath, and whose are all your ways, you have not honored" (Daniel 5:23).

That last line is one of the most frightening sentences in the Bible. "The God in whose hand is your breath." Belshazzar had been breathing the whole night. Every breath he took was a gift. The hand that wrote on the wall was the hand that was holding his lungs open. He could not see the hand that sustained him, but he could see the hand that judged him, and he was terrified of the wrong one.

It is possible to be terrified of the handwriting and still ignore the hand that holds your breath.

Daniel continues: "Then from his presence the hand was sent, and this writing was inscribed. And this is the writing that was inscribed: MENE, MENE, TEKEL, and PARSIN" (Daniel 5:24–25).

The words are not a code. They are measures. They are ordinary terms from the marketplace and the scale. Mene is a unit of weight or a count. Tekel is a weight. Peres is a division. God is not playing riddles. He is using the language of the counting house to say that the king's life has been counted, weighed, and divided.

"This is the interpretation of the matter: MENE, God has numbered the days of your kingdom and brought it to an end" (Daniel 5:26).

Numbered. The party had a clock. Every laugh, every toast, every cup had a number attached to it. The king did not know the number. God did. The days of the kingdom were not endless. They were counted out like coins on a table, and the last one had been spent.

"TEKEL, you have been weighed in the balances and found wanting" (Daniel 5:27).

Weighed. This is the center of the sermon. The king had spent the night measuring himself against other people. He was the host. He was the most important man in the room. He had a thousand lords who came when he called. He had the gold of the temple in his hand. By every measure Babylon used, he was a success.

But there is another scale.

God put Belshazzar in the balances, and the verdict was not "you were slightly underweight" or "you need to try harder." The verdict was "found wanting." The word means lacking, deficient,

not enough. All the gold in the room had no weight on that scale. The thousand lords had no weight. The purple, the chain, the third seat—no weight. The man himself was weightless.

That is a different kind of judgment than we usually imagine. We think of sin as a list of bad deeds that add up until the scale tips. But this is a weighing of the person. What is a life worth when it is held up against the glory of God? What is a kingdom worth when it is held up against the King of heaven? What is a man worth when the hand that holds his breath lets go?

"PARSIN, your kingdom is divided and given to the Medes and Persians" (Daniel 5:28).

Divided. The word peres sounds like the word for Persia. It is a pun with a knife in it. The kingdom that seemed so solid is being split like a loaf of bread. The Medes and the Persians are at the gate, and the king is still wearing his party clothes.

Daniel stops there. He does not add a call to repentance. He does not soften the sentence. He does not say, "But God is gracious, so maybe there is still time." He gives the interpretation and he is silent.

And Belshazzar does not repent.

"Then Belshazzar gave the command, and Daniel was clothed with purple, a chain of gold was put around his neck, and a proclamation was made about him, that he should be the third ruler in the kingdom" (Daniel 5:29).

This is the last thing the king does. He decorates the messenger.

He does not tear his clothes. He does not fall on his face. He does not call for the God of Daniel. He puts a chain on the old man and gives him a title. He is still managing the room. He is still trying to control the narrative. He is still treating the word of God as a transaction.

It is possible to reward the truth and still not obey it. It is possible to honor the preacher and ignore the sermon. It is possible to put a chain on Daniel and go to hell wearing it.

That is the tragedy of Belshazzar. His last recorded act is not a confession. It is a promotion.

# Movement 5: The night the kingdom fell

"That very night Belshazzar the Chaldean king was killed" (Daniel 5:30).

That is the whole funeral. One verse. No battle scene. No description of the siege. No last words. The man who had a thousand lords at his table is dead before the sun comes up.

The brevity is the point. The empire that seemed eternal ended in a single sentence. All the gold, all the power, all the wine, all the gods of silver and gold and bronze and iron and wood and stone—none of it held the door shut for even one more night.

History tells us that Babylon fell to Cyrus the Great in 539 BC. The Cyrus Cylinder, a clay record from the Persian court, boasts that Marduk allowed Cyrus to enter Babylon without battle. Herodotus, writing later, tells a more colorful story: the Persians diverted the Euphrates and walked into the city along the riverbed while the Babylonians were celebrating. The details are debated. The speed is not.

The Bible makes a theological claim, not a battle report: that very night, the sentence was executed. The city that thought it was invincible discovered that its walls were only as strong as the God who allowed them to stand.

"And Darius the Mede received the kingdom, being about sixty-two years old" (Daniel 5:31).

The kingdom changes hands. The old king is dead. The new king is in. The party is over. The writing on the wall has become the writing on the record.

I want you to see the final irony. Belshazzar was the second ruler in Babylon, and he made Daniel the third. But the kingdom was no longer his to give. He was handing out titles from a house that had already been deeded to someone else. He thought he was rewarding Daniel. He was actually proving that he had nothing left to give.

That is what happens when a man lives as though the world belongs to him. He spends his last night giving away what he does not own.

# Application: What do you do with the weight?

We have stood in the room. We have seen the hand. We have heard the sentence. Now the question is what we do with it.

This chapter is not a museum piece. It is a mirror. Belshazzar is not the only person who has ever held the things of God while ignoring the God of the things. He is not the only person who has ever known the family story and refused to let it change him. He is not the only person who has ever tried to buy a verdict.

So let us apply this to ourselves.

## 1. Stop decorating with the sacred

The temple vessels were not the problem. The problem was what Belshazzar did with them. He took what was holy and made it a decoration for his own party.

We do the same thing. We take the things of God and use them to decorate our own image. We use Scripture to win arguments instead of to examine our hearts. We use worship to create a mood instead of to meet with God. We use the Lord's Supper as a ritual we manage instead of a grace we receive. We use the name of Jesus as a brand, a badge, a way to signal that we are on the right side.

And we use people. The image of God in another human being is the most sacred thing in the room, and we use people all the time. We use them to feel important. We use them to build our platforms. We use them to tell ourselves that we are good because we are near someone who is.

The warning is not that you should be less religious. The warning is that you should stop using God's things for your own glory. A vessel carries the treasure. A trophy displays the owner. Which one are you?

## 2. Read the handwriting you already have

Belshazzar knew the story of Nebuchadnezzar. He knew what God had done to his predecessor. He had the evidence, and he ignored it. His judgment was not that he lacked information. It was that he had information and did not let it change him.

You have information too. You have the Scriptures you have read, the sermons you have heard, the prayers you have prayed, the people who have told you the truth. You have the warnings you have already received. You have the consequences you have already lived through.

What is the handwriting in your life that you have been walking past?

Maybe it is a pattern of behavior that you keep explaining away. Maybe it is a relationship that is being damaged by your pride. Maybe it is a habit that is quietly taking over. Maybe it is a conviction you have been ignoring because obeying it would cost you something. Maybe it is the still, small voice you have been drowning out with noise.

Do not wait for a hand on the wall. The hand has already written. The question is whether you will read it while there is time.

### 3. Do not try to buy the verdict

The king offered Daniel purple and gold. He was trying to purchase the interpretation, and underneath that, he was trying to purchase control. If he could pay for the news, maybe he could negotiate with the one who sent it. If he could reward the prophet, maybe the sentence would change.

We do this too. We try to bargain with God. We promise to do better if he will bless us. We give money or time or attention and quietly expect it to buy us a pass. We treat grace as a transaction and worship as a payment.

But you cannot buy a verdict. You cannot purchase the truth. You cannot put God in your debt. The only way to come is empty-handed.

That is the gospel. It is not a payment you make. It is a gift you receive. It is not a performance you offer. It is a sentence you cannot overturn and a Savior who took it for you.

### 4. Number your days

"Teach us to number our days, that we may get a heart of wisdom" (Psalm 90:12).

MENE means numbered. The days of Belshazzar's kingdom were counted, and he did not know the number. You do not know the number either. You do not know how many nights you have left, how many Sundays, how many conversations, how many chances to say the thing you have been afraid to say.

Numbering your days is not morbid. It is wise. It is the difference between a person who lives as though the party will never end and a person who knows the party is not the point. It is the difference between a king who decorates his last night and an exile who tells the truth for free.

The scale is not your neighbor's life. It is not your income. It is not your reputation. It is the glory of God. And when you weigh yourself against that, you will find that you are not enough. That is not the end of the story. It is the beginning of the gospel.

## The invitation

This chapter holds up two men. One is a king in purple who has everything and is about to lose it. The other is an exile in his eighth decade who has nothing and is free.

Which one are you?

If you are Belshazzar—if you have been drinking from cups that do not belong to you, if you have been using the sacred as a decoration, if you have known the truth and ignored it—hear the sentence. You are not being invited to clean up the party before you come. You are being invited to stop pretending the room is forever. You are being invited to lay down the gold and come to the God who holds your breath.

If you are Daniel—if you have been faithful in a room that has forgotten you, if you have watched the powerful take the credit, if you have wondered whether integrity is worth it—take heart. The Word of God does not return empty. The kingdom that seems secure may not be. The King who holds your breath is not impressed by purple. Stand where Daniel stood. Tell the truth for free.

The invitation is not "become worthy enough to be weighed." It is "come to the King who was weighed for you."

The writing on the wall was a sentence. The writing on the cross is a pardon.

Come.

# Response

In a moment, I am going to ask you to do something simple. Not to come forward. Not to stand. Just to be still.

In the quiet, I want you to picture the room. The table. The cups. The gold. The noise. And I want you to ask yourself: What am I holding that belongs to God?

Maybe it is a gift he gave you that you have been using for your own glory. Maybe it is a relationship you have been treating as a resource. Maybe it is a truth you have been avoiding. Maybe it is a person you have been using. Maybe it is your own breath.

Name it. Do not defend it. Do not explain it. Just name it.

Then say the sentence: "I have been weighed, and I am wanting."

Do not rush past that. Let it be true. You are not enough. Not on your own. Not on the scale of God's glory. That is the first honest thing any of us can say.

Then say the next sentence: "But there is a King who was weighed for me."

That is the gospel. Jesus Christ came into the world to take the weight we could not carry. He stood in the balances in our place. He took the sentence. He died the death that the writing on the wall pronounced. And on the third day, he rose.

If you are trusting in him, the verdict has already been given. There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1). Not because you are weightless. Because he had weight, and he spent it for you.

Let us pray.

Lord God, you are the Most High. You hold our breath in your hand. You number our days. You weigh our lives. We confess that we have taken your gifts and used them for our own glory. We have decorated our lives with the sacred and ignored the One who made them sacred. We have known the truth and refused to let it weigh us.

Have mercy on us.

Thank you that you did not leave us in the room with the writing on the wall. Thank you that you sent your Son, the true King, to stand in our place. Thank you that the sentence fell on him. Thank you that the handwriting against us was nailed to the cross.

Teach us to number our days. Give us hearts of wisdom. Make us free like Daniel, free enough to tell the truth and free enough to refuse the purple. And when we are tempted to decorate our lives with what belongs to you, remind us that the only thing worth holding is you.

We ask this in the name of Jesus. Amen.

# Closing

The hand wrote on the wall.

The hand held the king's breath.

And the hand of God is not only the hand of judgment. It is the hand that took the nails.

The writing on the wall was a sentence. The writing on the cross is a pardon.

The feast of Belshazzar ended in a single night. The feast of the Lamb has no end. Do not spend your one life decorating the wrong table.

Come to the King who holds your breath. Come while there is time.

May the Lord teach us to number our days.

And may he find us, not weightless, but hidden in the weight of his Son.

# Evidence note for the preacher

- Daniel 5 is a narrative in two languages: Aramaic, like Daniel 2–7, which places it in the same court-dream genre as the Nebuchadnezzar stories. The chapter is a self-contained drama built around a feast, a writing, an interpretation, and a fall.
- Belshazzar is not named outside the Bible except in cuneiform sources. The Nabonidus Cylinder, from Ur, records that Nabonidus entrusted the kingship to his eldest son Belshazzar. The Nabonidus Chronicle mentions Belshazzar as crown prince in the events of 539 BC. This fits the biblical portrait of a co-regent and explains the offer of "third ruler" in Daniel 5:7, 16, 29: Nabonidus was first, Belshazzar second, and Daniel would be third.
- The text calls Nebuchadnezzar Belshazzar's father. Belshazzar was the son of Nabonidus; "father" in royal court language can mean ancestor or predecessor. The exact genealogical link to Nebuchadnezzar is debated, and the sermon does not settle it. What matters for the text is that Belshazzar stood in the royal line and knew the family record.
- Babylon fell to Cyrus the Great in 539 BC. The Cyrus Cylinder claims a peaceful entry under Marduk's favor. Herodotus (Histories 1.191) describes the diversion of the Euphrates and an entry along the riverbed while the city was celebrating; Xenophon gives a similar account. The sources differ in detail and Herodotus writes long after the events, but they agree that the fall was sudden. The Bible's "that very night" is a theological claim, not a tactical timeline.
- Darius the Mede (Daniel 5:31) is not clearly identified in extrabiblical sources. Proposed identifications include Gubaru, a governor under Cyrus, and Cyrus himself under a different name. The sermon does not resolve the identity; it notes that the text presents him as the new ruler.
- The temple vessels were taken from Jerusalem by Nebuchadnezzar (2 Kings 24:13; 25:14–15; Daniel 1:2; 2 Chronicles 36:7, 10, 18) and later returned under Cyrus (Ezra 1:7–11; 5:14; 6:5). The gold and silver cups were not magic; they were holy because they were set apart for the worship of God.
- "MENE" is repeated in Daniel 5:25. Daniel interprets it once, but the repetition is emphatic: the sentence is certain. The words are ordinary Aramaic terms for counting, weighing, and dividing. "PARSIN" is the plural of peres, "divided," and it sounds like the Aramaic word for Persia—a wordplay Daniel exploits in 5:28.
- The writing was on plaster, opposite the lampstand (5:5), which means it was visible in the light. The text does not say the lampstand was the temple menorah; it is the lamp of the palace. The detail keeps the scene concrete.
- The queen of Daniel 5:10 is not named. Most interpreters take her to be the queen mother. She enters the banquet hall from outside, which suggests she was not part of the drinking party. She is the one who remembers Daniel.

- Daniel's refusal of the gifts (5:17) is not a rejection of all payment for ministry. Compare Luke 10:7 and 1 Corinthians 9:14. It is a refusal to let the message be bought, and a refusal to become part of a system that is under judgment.
- Daniel 4 is the background for Daniel's speech in 5:18–21. The sermon treats Belshazzar's knowledge of that story as the point of 5:22: his sin is not ignorance but suppressed knowledge.
- The gospel connection is Colossians 2:13–15: the record of debt that stood against us was canceled and nailed to the cross. The sermon uses the "handwriting" image deliberately, but it does not claim that Paul was quoting Daniel 5. The connection is thematic, not a direct citation.
- The Lord's Supper is not the same as Belshazzar's feast. The comparison in the application is about reverence and self-examination, not about the physical elements. Handle 1 Corinthians 11:27–29 carefully and do not use it to frighten people away from the table.
- Scripture quotations are ESV. The sermon follows the ESV's wording for Daniel 5 and uses the standard translations for the supporting texts.